Day 65 (stop 1 of 2) - Curly Harnden, Bruce Caves Access Trail

Bruce Trail side-trail plan (dog-friendly, max ~8 mi) · Sydenham section · hike 84 · Bruce's Caves & Colpoy's Bay escarpment

6.9 km / 4.3 mi	~2.2 h	2.4 km new	183 min
total walking	hiking, plus stops	side trail covered	drive from home, Sat 7 am

Park (P): Roadside parking on Gleason Lake Rd where the Curly Harnden Side Trail meets the Len Holley Side Trail. Google Maps. **Free**

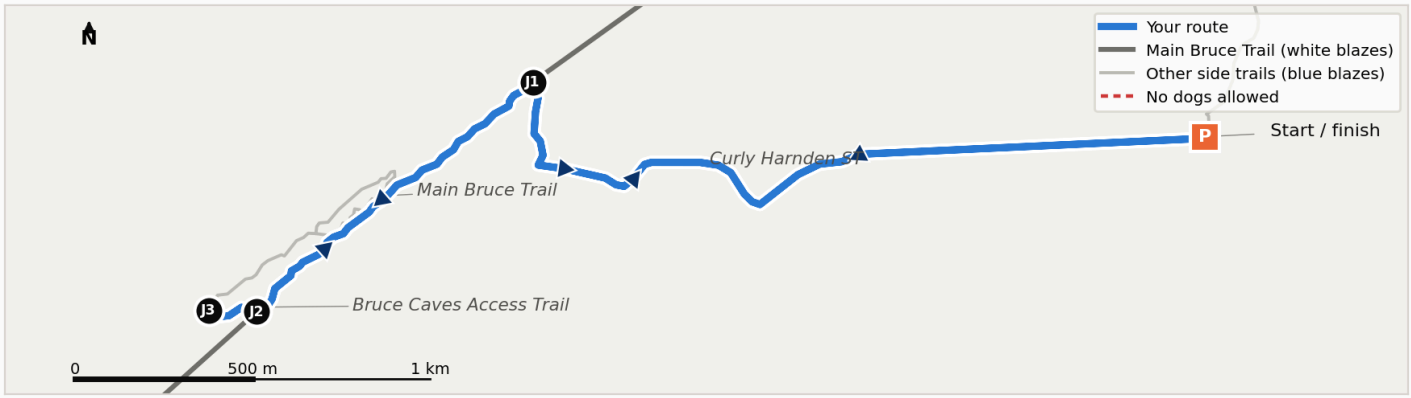
Navigate: import *day65a_hike084.gpx* into Gaia GPS. The track is the whole route in walking order, and the J waypoints match the directions below.

Side trails covered: Curly Harnden Side Trail (2.3 km); Bruce Caves Access Trail (0.2 km)

Same day: this is stop 1 of 2 on day 65 (7.1 mi of hiking, about 385 min total driving). Other stop(s): stop 2: hike 85, 2.8 mi from Bruce Trail parking lot located 50 metres from the end of Mallory Beach Rd, accessed....

Route map

Day 65 (stop 1 of 2) | 6.9 km (4.3 mi)



What to expect

- **Parking:** Roadside parking on Gleason Lake Rd, where the Curly Harnden and Len Holley side trails meet. The Bruce's Caves Conservation Area lot charges a fee from spring to fall and has a laneway that isn't maintained in winter, but this route doesn't need it.
- **Curly Harnden Side Trail:** A blue-blazed connector between Gleason Lake Rd and the main Bruce Trail. You walk it both ways.
- **Main Bruce Trail along the bluffs:** The Sydenham club describes the 11 km from Skinner's Bluff to Bruce's Caves as having many lookouts over Colpoy's Bay and plenty of picnic spots. Ontario Nature Trails notes views north over the bay to the Malcolm Bluffs. Stay back from cliff edges with Zappy.
- **Bruce's Caves:** These caves were formed by wave action from post-glacial Lake Algonquin. The conservation area's trail is rated moderate, with compacted-soil and stone surfaces.
- **Dogs:** Zappy stays on leash. The Sydenham club asks that dogs be leashed and kept under control, especially near farmland, and suggests an orange or fluorescent harness or bandana in hunting season so a dog isn't mistaken for wildlife.

Parking options

No other official Bruce Trail parking lies within about 1 km of this route. If you need to stop early, turn back the way you came; the GPS track records what you covered, and the website shows what is left.

Parking costs were checked in October 2026 from operator websites and Bruce Trail Conservancy data; prices and booking rules change, so check before you go.

Turn-by-turn

km	mi	Directions
0.0	0.0	Start at the parking: Roadside parking on Gleason Lake Rd where the Curly Harnden Side Trail meets the Len.... Head west on the blue-blazed Curly Harnden Side Trail. The next 1.0 km follows an unopened road allowance (rough track, no traffic).
2.3	1.4	J1: Turn left onto the white-blazed main Bruce Trail, heading south-west. (the white-blazed main Bruce Trail goes off on your right.)
3.3	2.1	J2: Turn right onto the blue-blazed Bruce Caves Access Trail, heading west. (the white-blazed main Bruce Trail goes off ahead.)
3.5	2.2	J3: End of the Bruce Caves Access Trail. Turn around and retrace your steps.

3.6	2.3	J2: Turn left onto the white-blazed main Bruce Trail, heading north-east. (the white-blazed main Bruce Trail goes off on your right.)
4.7	2.9	J1: Turn right onto the blue-blazed Curly Harnden Side Trail, heading south. (the white-blazed main Bruce Trail goes off ahead.)
6.0	3.7	Heads-up: The next 1.0 km follows an unopened road allowance (rough track, no traffic).
6.9	4.3	Back at the parking. Hike complete.

Distances and junctions are computed from the Bruce Trail Conservancy's trail data (Bruce County GIS). Left/right is calculated from the trail geometry. Use it as a guide, follow the blazes, and check the Conservancy's trail-change notices before you go. Dogs must be leashed everywhere on the Bruce Trail. Trail descriptions draw on Visit Grey (Grey Sauble Conservation), the Sydenham Bruce Trail Club and Ontario Nature Trails.